

We understand the transition away from live sheep export by sea may be distressing for some people. There are many existing online, phone and face-to-face resources available.

Key support numbers:

- Lifeline - 13 11 14
- Farmer Assistance Hotline - 13 23 16
- Rural West - 1800 612 004

Current options for more support

The Rural Financial Counselling Service (RFCS) is an ongoing Australian Government program providing free and independent financial counselling to eligible farmers, fishers, foresters and small related businesses experiencing, or at risk of, financial hardship.

The RFCS is free and confidential. It helps to build financially capable agricultural, fishing and forestry sectors that are profitable, financially self-reliant and better prepared to deal with risks.

RFCS Counsellors can help you:

- understand your financial position
- develop budgets and cash flows to re-assess the viability of your business
- develop an action plan and assist you to take the steps necessary to get you out of financial difficulty
- negotiate with your lenders
- build your financial knowledge, skills and resilience so you can manage potential challenges in the future
- assist you to apply for other government programs and assistance that will support the path back to self-sufficiency

An additional \$2.4 million has been committed to the RFCS in Western Australian (WA) to assist those who may be impacted by the transition.

For more information visit the [Rural Financial Counselling Service of WA – Rural West](#).

The Community Wellbeing Program is a \$1.5 million initiative [administered by the Western Australian Government](#). It supports activities that promote resilience communities affected by the phase out of live sheep exports by sea. Activities will be delivered across the sheep producing regions of Western Australia, with funding allocated to the following organisations:

Rural Aid – individual and family support

Rural Aid is providing counselling and wellbeing support to farmers, their families and farm workers impacted by the phase out.

Services include:

- one-on-one counselling available in person or by phone, with dedicated counsellor positions based in regional WA
- delivery of the Mustering Growth in school program, supporting the wellbeing of young people in agricultural communities.

To learn more about Rural Aid and the services available, visit [Rural Aid - Supporting Rural Communities](#).

Holyoake – mental health training

Holyoake is delivering targeted mental health training to equip farmers, families, frontline workers and industry leaders with practical skills to manage stress, support others, and strengthen community resilience.

Training programs include:

- Standard Mental Health First Aid Course
- Accidental Counsellor Workshop
- Agribalance+ Workshop.

To learn more about Holyoake, visit [Holyoake: Specialist training and education for Agricultural and Rural Communities](#).

Blue Tree Project – community connection events

Blue Tree Project will deliver a series of community events designed to:

- build mental health awareness
- inspire open conversations
- provide practical wellbeing tools
- connect communities with trained professionals
- offer access to free resources and support.

These events aim to strengthen community connection and promote positive mental health across regional areas.

To learn more about the Blue Tree Project, visit [Blue Tree Project: Community events](#).

A farm management deposit (FMD) account allows you to make tax deductible deposits during years of good cash flow, and withdraw them during bad years. This is designed to help Australian primary producers manage their financial risk and meet their business costs in low-income years, by building up cash reserves.

For more information on FMD accounts and withdrawals, visit [Farm management deposits \(ato.gov.au\)](#) and our [Farm Management Deposits](#) page.

The Regional Investment Corporation (RIC) is a national low-interest loan specialist funded by the Australian Government for farm business and farm-related small businesses.

RIC's low-interest loans directly benefit farm businesses Australia-wide, saving them thousands of dollars in interest payments each year. These interest savings help farmers who have experienced significant financial disruption from drought, natural disasters, and cumulative events to improve cash flow so they can manage through, recover and rebuild.

This financial 'breathing space' enables farmers to plan, fund risk mitigation activities and adapt practices to be ready and prepared for potential future business impacts.

RIC loans help accelerate business plans for first farmers and support succession planning.

The [Minister announced](#) on 31 March 2026 that applications are now open for the Drought Hardship Loan. The Drought Hardship Loan is designed to support farm businesses that have managed through at least 24 months of drought and continue to face significant financial impacts.

For more information on the Regional Investment Corporation Concessional Loans, please visit [Our Loans \(ric.gov.au\)](#).

Job Coordinators are trained professionals who provide workforce and employment solutions via the Local Jobs Program. They bring together businesses, employment and skills services, and community organisations to connect you with training, jobs and support services.

Their support includes:

- Connecting you with programs, services, funding opportunities and resources in your local area.
- Providing advice to help businesses get the most out of hiring practices to attract and retain the right staff.
- Work with organisations to develop workforce initiatives and solutions.
- Share information and insights about the skills and workforce priorities and actions in the Local Jobs Plan.

There are several job coordinators located across WA, which you can find by visiting [Western Australia - Department of Employment and Workplace Relations \(dewr.gov.au\)](#).

Employer Liaison Officers are trained professionals who help large businesses and priority industries, including agriculture, find the staff they need.

They do this through:

- Helping you understand and use government services
- Designing solutions to benefit you and whole industries
- Connecting you to people, services and programs that meet your needs
- Informing participants about the industry, the employer and the available jobs.

For more information on Employer Liaison Officers, please visit [Linking people to jobs \(workforceaustralia.gov.au\)](#).

We understand that the transition away from live sheep exports by sea may be distressing for some people. Change can affect wellbeing. There are free [social support and wellbeing services](#) available, including:

- family support services
- crisis counselling
- advice and referrals.

The Western Australian Government also provides information about [rural support services](#).

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/biosecurity-trade/export/controlled-goods/live-animals/livestock/live-sheep-exports-phase-out/support-services>